see also Bauer, *The History of the Medieval World*, pp. 98ff. The Buddhism of the Palas tended towards the Theravada school but incorporated many other elements. “Classical Buddhism” is a shorthand phrase for those elements held in common by Theravada, Mahayana, and most other practitioners of Buddhism.

*“Hinduism” is a term that covers a vast range of beliefs and practices which developed over five thousand years. Most forms of Hinduism share the following beliefs: one divine essence, that can, however, be manifested in multiple ways, so that the gods and goddesses of Hindu practice are to be understood as many faces of the one divine; life as a cycle that repeats again and again; humans as two-part beings, containing both an unchanging essence of the divine (the *atman*) and a personality (*jivatman*), which is made up of experience, character, and all those things that differentiate us from one another. In Hindu practice, the actions of the *jivatman* produce *karma*: good actions and intentions produce good karma, bad choices produce bad karma. The Hindu believer strives to produce good karma by living by *dharma*, what is good and right. A life lived by dharma produces good karma, with the result that the believer’s reincarnation in the next cycle of life will be as a higher and better being. Ultimately, the believer hopes that, after many reincarnations, he will perfect the ability to live by dharma; as a result, he will finally be freed from his *jivatman*, his personality, and consist only of *atman*, the essence of the divine. At that point, he will become one with the divine “like the river merges into the sea”—he will lose his distinctiveness as a single person and be freed from the cycle of reincarnation. Jeaneane D. Fowler’s *Hinduism: Beliefs and Practices* (Sussex Academic Press, 1997) is an excellent nontechnical introduction to the basics of Hinduism and its many variations.

*“Caste” is an immensely complicated system, and the subject of too many detailed scholarly studies to list here. I have here taken the position of Bernard S. Cohn, who held that although caste has always been a essential element of Hindu culture, the British, in their attempts to understand a strange and foreign system, “reduced vastly complex codes and their associated meanings to a few metonyms.” See his *Colonialism and Its Forms of Knowledge: The British in India* (Princeton University Press, 1996), p. 162. For our purposes, it is enough to note that, although Indian caste *was* less flexible than European socioeconomic categories, the move from peasant to landowner in the north of India was not much more difficult than, say, the move from peasant to knight in twelfth-century Germany.